

Teen ailments

Changing hormones, anxiety over tests, and close physical contact with peers are just a few of the factors that make teens particularly susceptible to some infections and medical conditions.

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Potential problems

The ailments listed here can affect teenagers. This is because teens' bodies are going through many changes, and teens spend much of their time in group environments.

A person's immune system works hard to protect them against the constant barrage of infectious pathogens, such as bacteria, viruses, fungi, and parasites, that come with living a normal life. But it sometimes needs help, so it's important to be aware of these ailments, to take steps to reduce the chances of infection, and to seek medical advice if necessary.

Measles

A viral illness, recognizable by its rash, that is highly contagious

Complications: Eye, liver, lung, or neurological damage; can be fatal

Causes: The measles virus

Symptoms: Cold-like symptoms, fever, light sensitivity, red and sore eyes, skin rash, whitish spots on the inside of the mouth

Diagnosis: Blood or saliva sample, clinical diagnosis

Treatment: Fever relief, painkillers; symptoms usually improve on their own within 7–10 days

Tips for prevention: Vaccination



Mononucleosis

A viral infection that affects mostly young people

Complications: Enlarged lymph nodes, prolonged tiredness, sometimes a decrease in blood cells, damage to spleen, neurological problems

Causes: Epstein-Barr virus, often spread through saliva, such as by kissing, sharing toothbrushes, sharing utensils

Symptoms: Extreme tiredness, fever, sore throat, swollen glands in neck

Diagnosis: Blood test

Treatment: Fluids, painkillers, rest

Tips for prevention: Avoid sharing drinks or eating utensils, avoid kissing people if they're ill



Meningitis

Inflammation of the meninges—the membranes around the spinal cord and brain

Complications: Neurological damage, loss of limbs; can be fatal if not treated quickly

Causes: Bacterial (more dangerous) or viral (more common) infection, often spread through sneezing, coughing, kissing, or sharing utensils

Symptoms: Aching muscles, blotchy rash that doesn't fade when a glass is rolled over it, drowsiness, fever, headache, sensitivity to light, seizures, vomiting

Diagnosis: Blood tests and testing fluid from around the spinal cord and brain

Treatment: Immediate hospital treatment, with fluids, intravenous antibiotics, and oxygen (bacterial meningitis); viral meningitis tends to resolve itself within 7–10 days

Tips for prevention: Vaccination—several available

